

The bags broke, of course. The handles ripped off the brown paper. The speaker fell onto the street, and a piece flew off. The clothes spilled out onto where people had spit and peed and fornicated. It was garbage, and I was garbage too. I sat down on the sidewalk and leaned against a building, my knees to my chest, and cried. It was gross, but I was too sad to care. And because it was New York City, no one else cared either.

I did not know what to do. I had an account in the red, and I'd never applied for a credit card before. The idea terrified me. I wouldn't get one for another couple of years. I made up my mind to leave my internship to go back to Florida and stay with my parents. There, I could collect the money from my sublet Allston apartment and try to get my bank account back in the black.

This is what should have happened. This could have, in hindsight, been the straw that broke the camel's back and the way for me to finally clean up my act.

What happened instead was that I called my grandmother and cried. Meme agreed to pay my rent for one month, buying me a month of scrounging up the amount for the next month's rent, which I did with some freelance blogging gigs and a bit more success selling clothing at different outlets.

At the time, I was so grateful to her for covering for me so I could stay in New York and finish my internship. But the experts call what she did that day "enabling." And it was enabling that allowed me to get by paycheck to paycheck without doing anything substantial to fix my life for years to come. I didn't have to start handling money differently. Whenever it seemed that there was no hope, some kind of "miracle" would happen to keep me afloat for another few days. This might seem like a good thing, but in the long term, it wasn't. I needed to fall to get back up.

For example: When I was 15, my alcoholic dad crashed his car on the highway. He had an empty bottle of Crown Royal under his seat. The EMTs loaded him into the back of the ambulance, and for a reason he can't remember (and that I suspect was white privilege), he was never charged with a DUI. Years later, I said something offhand about how lucky he was to walk away from that night without jail time. He said he wasn't lucky. Getting away with driving drunk had only further convinced him of his own infallibility. It had just been another close call in a long series of close calls he thought of as "daily life." "The